

Trade Unionist and Socialist Coalition Manifesto 2021



WELSH
TRADE UNIONIST AND
SOCIALIST COALITION



Socialist Manifesto for the 2021 Senedd
elections



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For socialist change in Wales

Introduction

The Trade Unionist and Socialist Coalition (TUSC) is standing candidates for the Senedd in every region of Wales to provide a real alternative for working people. We need socialist champions for the working class who will stand up for their interests.

Who was it that kept society going during the lockdowns?

It wasn't the billionaires or the CEOs - it was health workers, care workers, teachers, supermarket workers, bus drivers, posties and other key workers. And it was those workers who paid the highest price with the highest death rates in the pandemic.

But it is also the working class who will be required by the Welsh and UK governments to pay the bill for the economic cost of the pandemic – in jobs, cuts in services and pay cuts.

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TUSC members of the Senedd will stand up and fight these cuts. We will represent the interests of working people in the Senedd. They will speak up for the working class – opposing real pay cuts, like the nurses 1%, or job losses.

And as we come out of the Covid crisis Wales is facing the threat of even greater cuts to funding to its public services from the Tory government in Westminster. TUSC will fight to oppose all cuts.

Already our services have undergone a decade of austerity – that have left vital services hanging by threads. It is also clear that Labour and Plaid Cymru are incapable of defending working people in Wales from those cuts.

Under Labour control the Welsh NHS has seen cut after cut – hospitals closed and services reduced. The cuts have been so severe that it meant that we entered the Covid pandemic with the lowest number of intensive care beds per capita in Western Europe – our NHS very nearly buckled under the strain.

And the effects of poverty left our communities suffering some of the highest death rates in the UK.

Plaid Cymru councils too meekly implemented cuts to services in the councils they controlled.

The Trade Unionist and Socialist Coalition (TUSC) has a manifesto for the Senedd elections which could make a real difference. Even one MS taking a stand, if they used their position in the Senedd chamber to appeal to those outside, could give confidence to local trade unionists and community campaigners to campaign for social justice.

The Trade Unionist and Socialist Coalition is standing to propose a real programme of reforms:

Public spending cuts

Sadly the Covid crisis means that more Tory austerity will be on its way to Wales – the working class will be expected to foot the bill for the economic effects of the crisis, just as working class communities suffered the worst from the effects of the virus itself.

It is expected that NHS spending will be 8% less than the level in 2010-11 before the cuts began. Now more than ever we need a Welsh government that will stand up for working people in Wales against more cuts.

Instead of passively implementing the cuts it can refuse to carry out Tory cuts and begin a mass campaign to force the Westminster government to return the funds denied to public services. In the 1980s Liverpool City Council with a socialist leadership refused to cut back services and instead successfully demanded extra funds from the Thatcher government to expand council housing, education and other services. If one city could force the 'iron lady' to back down in 1984 imagine what an entire nation could achieve against a weak and divided Tory government.

The next time it receives a budget from Westminster that demands further cuts it can pool its reserves with Welsh local authorities, refuse to implement further cuts and instead spend what working people in Wales need on the NHS, education, social services, housing.

It can use this breathing space to take its campaign to all our communities desperate for these services and mobilise them in a national campaign to fight for what we need. The campaign should draw on the hundreds of thousands of trade union members and the best traditions of the Welsh workers' movement with a dynamic campaign of workplace rallies, demonstrations and strikes to resist Tory austerity.



The multiple U-turns made by Johnson and his chancellor, spending billions when the pressure is on them, show that if the Welsh government used the powers it has to refuse to implement any more cuts and spend what is necessary instead, the Tories could be made to pay up and return the cash they have stolen from Wales and our public services.

- Opposition to all cuts and closures to public services, jobs, pay and conditions. We reject the claim that 'some cuts' are necessary to our services or that the Covid crisis is a reason for austerity.
- Refuse to carry out further cuts to public spending
- Reject income tax, council tax, rent and service charge increases for working class people to make up for cuts in funding and demand the UK government restores the cuts in funding it has imposed.
- Support a “needs budget” for Welsh public services that outlines what our communities and services need to end poverty and fight for the resources to carry them out
- Vote against the outsourcing, privatisation of public sector jobs and services, or the transfer of council services to 'social enterprises' or 'arms-length' management organisations, which are first steps to privatisation. Bring all services back “in-house”.

Fighting poverty

Even prior to the Covid crisis one third of Welsh children lived in poverty. The crisis will widen the inequality gap. Urgent action must be tackle low pay, unemployment and poverty.

Despite the limited powers of the Welsh government a number of policies can be implemented and fought for:

- Free school meals for all school-aged children in Wales
- A minimum wage of £12 an hour
- Ban compulsory zero hour contracts



NHS

Under Welsh Labour governments dozens of hospitals have been closed. The number of beds since 2008 have been cut by 21% which has meant that Wales entered the Covid crisis with the lowest number of intensive care beds per person in western Europe – lower even than NHS England under the Tories.



- Reverse all cuts to the NHS since 2010
- Restore the loss of hospital beds
- A crash training programme to train doctors and nurses – promise every medical student, nursing student and medical professional student free education and bursaries in exchange for a promise to work in the Welsh NHS for 10 years
- Expansion in the number of ambulances and paramedics available to reduce emergency waiting times
- A&E provision to be returned to local hospitals like and the number of intensive care beds returned to the pre-austerity levels.
- End privatisation of NHS services

Employment rights

£2 billion has been handed out to employers in Wales throughout the crisis but there has been very little support for workers attempting to shield or isolate during the pandemic. Some employers receiving grants from the Welsh government have openly flouted Covid government regulations and forced their workers to work in unsafe conditions, putting their lives at risk. Even the UK government has created a super spreading event at DVLA in Swansea.

Many low paid workers have been forced to choose between isolating and putting their livelihoods in jeopardy or breaking Covid rule to keep their jobs. Statutory sick pay has been so low that works have been forced to go to work when infected.



Employers have been able to get away with forcing workers to work in these conditions because of the lack of employment rights. TUSC calls for:

- All Welsh government contracts and grants to be restricted to companies that respect ethical employment practices and health and safety regulations
- An end to compulsory zero hour contracts
- Abolish anti-trade union laws

Climate Change

All parties are offering platitudes to oppose climate change, but only TUSC is proposing a socialist green new deal that can prevent carbon emissions and ensure a just transition to a green economy that protects jobs:

- Invest in tidal lagoons at Swansea Bay, Cardiff and North Wales
- Take Tata into public ownership and invest in hydrogen-based steel technology at Port Talbot to protect jobs and produce “green steel”
- Electrify Welsh railways
- Massively expand access to public transport (see below)



Education

All levels of education have been underfunded in Wales which has meant larger and larger class sizes, cancellation of courses and over-worked education workers. TUSC calls for:

- Publicly-provided nursery care to be available to all children in Wales
- Extended maternity leave
- More outdoor teaching areas in primaries – stop the sell off and building on school playing fields
- Limit teachers' workload
- Further education colleges to be brought back under local authority control
- No class sizes over 20 through the employment of extra teachers
- Education is a right – not a privilege so university tuition fees should be scrapped and a grant paid to allow students to study without having to work through uni etc.
- Full Educational Maintenance Allowance should be restored to all 16-18 year olds and brought up to levels that allow young people to live and study at the same time



Transport

- The permanent renationalisation of rail and buses including the rail infrastructure and for an integrated public transport system
- Reduce fares on public transport to make it affordable and encourage people to use cars less as a step to free public transport



Housing

A growing housing crisis in Wales is leading to growing homelessness and overcrowding which were cruelly exposed in the Covid crisis.

But at the same time the crisis showed that decisive action could be taken by the Welsh government and councils that could provide instant solutions.

For example, why not extend the scheme that housed the homeless during the first lockdown and banned evictions and make them permanent?



- Extend the scheme to house the homeless and ban evictions
- Re-introduce fair rents – rent control that would put a ceiling on rents in each area through the return of rent tribunals so that people will not have to spend huge amounts on rent.
- Pass a law only allowing secure tenancies – people should not have to pack up all their possessions and move every six or 12 months. For families it is even worse - children have their education disrupted by constantly changing schools. Secure tenancies with fair rents would allow people to stay in their homes so long as they paid the rent and did not damage the properties. No fault evictions must be made illegal.
- Build 20,000 council homes
- Rent control for private tenants and secure tenancies

Tackling racism and discrimination

TUSC believes everyone should have equal rights regardless of their race or ethnicity. Clearly that is not the case in Wales and series of cases have shown that there exists institutional racism within public bodies and especially the criminal justice system.

The deaths of Mohamoud Mohammed Hassan in Cardiff and Moyied Bashir in Newport in or shortly after police custody has shown that the police are not accountable.

The arrest and imprisonment of Siyanda Mngaza and the failure to properly investigate the death of Christopher Kapessa also show that the judicial system racially discriminates against black people in Wales.

Young black men are 19 times more likely to be stopped and searched by the police. Black people are nine times more likely to be imprisoned.

- Wales needs a police force that is under democratic community control so that the police are accountable to the communities they are meant to protect, not accountable only to themselves or the discredited IOPC.



Photo: Rachel Barwell